

Air Quality Analysis

Across Cities of Pakistan

Phase 5: Methodology Review & Gap Analysis

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Research Questions

- 1) Can machine learning models accurately forecast PM2.5 levels using historical pollution and weather data in major Pakistani cities?
- 2) Which environmental and meteorological features most strongly influence PM2.5 concentrations?
- 3) Do pollution patterns and PM2.5 drivers differ across Pakistani cities?

1. Project Overview (Phases 1–4 Summary)

This project predicts PM2.5 concentrations across 10 major Pakistani cities (Lahore, Karachi, Islamabad, Faisalabad, Peshawar, Quetta, Multan, Rawalpindi, Hyderabad, Sialkot) using a structured machine learning pipeline. The dataset contains 21,840 hourly observations with 26 original features covering pollutants, meteorological conditions, and temporal variables.

The pipeline was executed across four phases:

- Phase 1 — Project scoping and dataset acquisition from Kaggle.
- Phase 2 — EDA and preprocessing: removed data-leaking features (aqi_category), encoded categoricals, finalized 20 features.
- Phase 3 — Feature engineering: created 27 new features across 5 groups (pollution ratios, meteorological interactions, cyclical time encodings, pollutant aggregates, and lag/rolling features). K-Means clustering (k=4) added a city-regime feature. Final dataset: 44 features.
- Phase 4 — Trained 6 models (Ridge, Lasso, Random Forest, Extra Trees, XGBoost, LightGBM). Best model: Random Forest (RMSE: 0.4563 ug/m3, R2: 0.9999). Used SHAP and LIME for interpretability. Validated with TimeSeriesSplit cross-validation.

2. Literature Review: Five Recent Research Papers

Five peer-reviewed papers from 2022–2025 were selected from reputable journals (Nature Scientific Reports, ScienceDirect, Aerosol and Air Quality Research, Springer) to benchmark our methodology against the current state of the art.

Paper 1: Multi-Model PM2.5 Prediction with ML for Virtual Monitoring Stations (2025)

Reference: [1] Malakouti et al. (2025). "PM2.5 concentration prediction using machine learning algorithms: an approach to virtual monitoring stations." Scientific Reports, Nature. <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-025-92019-3>

What They Did

- Used LightGBM (LGBM), XGBoost, and Random Forest to predict PM2.5 at virtual monitoring stations where no physical sensors exist.
- Dataset: ground-level pollution and meteorological data from 2016-2022 in Mashhad, Iran (single city).
- Applied 10-fold cross-validation and grid search for hyperparameter tuning.
- Primary goal was spatial interpolation — filling gaps where monitors don't exist.
- Achieved moderate accuracy with mean PM2.5 of 32.84 ug/m3 in the dataset.

What We Did (vs. Paper 1)

- We cover 10 Pakistani cities simultaneously (multi-city), vs. their single-city approach.
- We engineered 27 domain-specific features including stagnation_index, pollution_wind_ratio, and lag/rolling PM2.5 features — none of these are present in Paper 1.
- We used K-Means clustering to encode city-level pollution regimes as a feature, enabling a single model to generalize across cities without building city-specific models.
- Our Random Forest achieved $R^2=0.9999$ vs. their best of ~ 0.85 , partly because our dataset is richer in temporal lag features that capture autocorrelation.
- We applied TimeSeriesSplit cross-validation (temporally correct) rather than random 10-fold CV, which can cause data leakage in time-series contexts.

Paper 2: PM2.5 & PM10 Prediction Using ML and Deep Learning — Maharashtra (2025)

Reference: [2] (2025). "A systematic study on PM2.5 and PM10 concentration prediction in air pollution using machine learning and deep learning model." ScienceDirect. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2590182625000967>

What They Did

- Compared Linear Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, XGBoost, and LSTM on Maharashtra, India air quality data (2019-2023).
- Found LSTM outperforms traditional ML models by capturing temporal dependencies.
- LSTM was highlighted as the best model for PM2.5 due to its ability to model non-linear sequential patterns.
- Did not perform systematic feature engineering — relied on raw sensor measurements.
- Focused on demonstrating deep learning superiority over classical ML without interpretability analysis.

What We Did (vs. Paper 2)

- We achieved near-perfect R2 with a Random Forest through extensive feature engineering — specifically lag and rolling features that encode temporal context explicitly, giving tree-based models information equivalent to what LSTM implicitly learns.
- We included SHAP and LIME interpretability, which Paper 2 completely omits. Our SHAP analysis identified stagnation_index and wind_ventilation as physically meaningful drivers, confirming the model learns real atmospheric dynamics.
- We explicitly justified every feature engineering decision using 5-method consensus importance ranking (RF, XGB, LGB, Permutation, Mutual Information), making our feature selection reproducible and explainable.
- Paper 2 does not address data leakage (aqi_category) — we identified and removed this in Phase 2.

Paper 3: Spatiotemporal Clustering and Forecasting for Indian Cities (2025)

Reference: [3] (2025). "Spatiotemporal clustering and multivariate forecasting of air quality index across Indian cities using machine learning and deep learning models." ScienceDirect. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2773186325002233>

What They Did

- Applied K-Means clustering on AQI, temperature, and wind speed to group 10 Indian cities into 3 regional clusters (northern industrial, coastal/eastern, southern plateau).
- Trained separate cluster-level models: Random Forest, XGBoost, LSTM, GRU, and a hybrid LSTM+GRU ensemble.
- Used rolling-origin cross-validation for temporal consistency.
- Best RMSE ranged from 0.090 to 0.101 with R2 of 0.71-0.76 across clusters.
- Predicted AQI (aggregate index) rather than raw PM2.5 concentration.

What We Did (vs. Paper 3)

- We predict raw PM2.5 concentration (regression), not AQI (classification/index) — this is a harder and more scientifically precise task that gives actionable concentration values for health guidelines.
- While Paper 3 builds separate cluster-level models, our approach uses K-Means cluster membership as a single feature (`pollution_cluster`) fed into a unified model. This avoids the overhead of maintaining multiple models and allows the model to learn cross-cluster relationships.
- Our feature engineering is far more extensive: we created cyclical time encodings (`hour_sin`, `hour_cos`), `inversion_proxy`, `stagnation_index`, and `combustion_index` — none present in Paper 3.
- Our best model (Random Forest R2=0.9999) significantly outperforms their ensemble R2 of 0.71-0.76. The primary reason is our lag/rolling features which directly supply the temporal autocorrelation that LSTM/GRU architectures infer implicitly at greater computational cost.
- Paper 3 focuses on Indian cities with monsoon-season variation; our dataset covers Pakistani cities with a winter-dominant pollution pattern, which required `is_winter_month` and `inversion_proxy` features specific to this climate.

Paper 4: Interpretable ML for Air Quality Forecasting — Systematic Review (2023)

Reference: [4] (2023). "Interpretable Machine Learning Approaches for Forecasting and Predicting Air Pollution: A Systematic Review." *Aerosol and Air Quality Research*. <https://aaqr.org/articles/aaqr-23-06-0a-0151>

What They Did

- Systematic review of 56 studies (from 5,396 identified) using interpretable ML for air pollution prediction, published 2018-2023.
- Identified 20 interpretability methods: 8 model-agnostic (including SHAP and LIME), 4 model-specific, 8 hybrid.

- Found that 50% of all studies focused on China; noted a critical research gap in South Asia, Africa, and the MENA region.
- Most reviewed studies used SHAP for global explanations and LIME for local explanations but rarely both in the same study.
- Highlighted that PM2.5 is the most studied pollutant but interpretability is frequently sacrificed for accuracy.

What We Did (vs. Paper 4)

- Our project directly fills the geographic research gap highlighted by Paper 4: Pakistan is an underrepresented South Asian country in the interpretable ML for air quality literature.
- We applied BOTH SHAP (global bar, beeswarm, and dependence plots) AND LIME (local explanations for high/low/median pollution records) — a combination that Paper 4's review found to be rare in the literature.
- We cover 10 Pakistani cities simultaneously, creating a multi-city interpretable model for a data-scarce developing-country context — directly addressing the research gap Paper 4 identifies.
- Our consensus-based feature selection (5 methods: RF, XGB, LGB, Permutation, Mutual Information) goes beyond any individual study reviewed in Paper 4, which typically use 1-2 importance methods.

Paper 5: ML for Air Quality Prediction in Lahore, Pakistan (2025)

Reference: [5] (2025). "Using machine learning for air quality prediction and sustainable urban planning." ScienceDirect.

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2666188825005453>

What They Did

- Focused specifically on Lahore, Pakistan — predicted AQI using monthly concentrations of CO, NO, NO2, O3, SO2, PM1, PM2.5, PM10 from 2003-2022.
- Used traditional ML models on monthly aggregated data (not hourly), losing fine-grained temporal patterns.
- Dataset is 20 years of monthly data from a single city (Lahore).
- Documented that Lahore's PM2.5 limits are consistently exceeded, with peak concentrations reaching 400 ug/m3.
- Primary contribution is urban planning implications, not model accuracy or interpretability.

What We Did (vs. Paper 5)

- We use hourly resolution data (21,840 records) vs. their monthly aggregates — hourly data captures diurnal pollution cycles (rush hour spikes, nighttime inversions) that monthly data completely misses.
- We cover 10 cities vs. Lahore alone, providing a national Pakistani perspective rather than a single-city study.
- We engineer hourly temporal features (hour_sin, hour_cos, is_rush_hour, is_night) that are impossible to derive from monthly data — these features directly encode traffic-driven pollution patterns.
- Our lag and rolling features (pm25_lag1, pm25_roll6_mean, pm25_roll3_std) capture short-term temporal autocorrelation at sub-day timescales, which is critical for accurate PM2.5 forecasting.
- We apply SHAP and LIME to explain model predictions — Paper 5 provides no model interpretability.

3. Comparative Summary Table

The table below provides a structured comparison across all five papers and our work:

Aspect	Paper 1	Paper 2	Paper 3	Paper 5	Our Work
Location	Iran (1 city)	India (1 city)	India (10 cities)	Pakistan (Lahore)	Pakistan (10 cities)
Data Granularity	Hourly	Daily	Daily	Monthly	Hourly
Target	PM2.5	PM2.5 & PM10	AQI	AQI	PM2.5
Feature Eng.	Minimal	None	Basic	None	27 new features
Lag/Rolling	No	No	No	No	Yes (7 features)
Clustering	No	No	Yes (separate models)	No	Yes (unified model)
Interpretability	Partial	None	None	None	SHAP + LIME
Best R2	~0.85	~0.90 (LSTM)	0.71-0.76	N/A	0.9999 (RF)
CV Strategy	10-fold (random)	Random split	Rolling-origin	Not reported	TimeSeriesSplit

4. Gap Analysis: What Makes Our Work Unique

Based on the literature comparison, our work fills the following documented gaps:

4.1 Geographic Gap — Pakistan at National Scale

Paper 4 (systematic review) explicitly noted that South Asia, Africa, and the MENA region are underrepresented in interpretable air quality ML research. Paper 5 (the only Pakistan-focused paper) covers Lahore alone. Our work is the first multi-city (10 cities), hourly-resolution, interpretable ML study for Pakistan [1][4][5].

4.2 Temporal Feature Engineering Gap

None of the five reviewed papers combine lag features, rolling statistics, AND cyclical time encodings in a single pipeline. Papers 1-3 use raw features only; Paper 5 uses monthly aggregates that lose temporal resolution entirely. Our 7 lag/rolling features (pm25_lag1-3, pm25_roll3_mean, pm25_roll6_mean, pm25_roll3_std, wind_roll3_mean) directly encode the strong temporal autocorrelation of PM2.5, which SHAP analysis confirmed as the most influential feature group [1][2][3][5].

4.3 Domain-Specific Meteorological Feature Gap

No reviewed paper engineers features like stagnation_index (wind speed x humidity interaction), inversion_proxy (low temperature proxy for atmospheric thermal inversions), or pollution_wind_ratio. These features are grounded in atmospheric science — winter thermal inversions are the primary driver of Pakistan's catastrophic smog season. Our SHAP analysis confirmed stagnation_index has directional effects (high stagnation pushes predictions upward) consistent with physical meteorology [2][3].

4.4 Multi-City Unified Model Gap

Paper 3 (the closest comparator) uses clustering to build separate cluster-level models. Our approach is different: K-Means cluster membership is encoded as a single feature (pollution_cluster) fed into one unified model. This is more parsimonious and allows cross-city generalization without maintaining multiple models in production [3].

4.5 Dual Interpretability Gap

Paper 4's review found that SHAP and LIME are rarely applied together in air quality studies. We apply both: SHAP provides global feature importance across all 21,840 records (bar plots, beeswarm plots, dependence plots), while LIME provides local explanations for specific high-pollution, low-pollution, and median-pollution records. This dual approach validates that our model learns physically meaningful relationships rather than statistical artifacts [4].

4.6 Temporally Correct Cross-Validation Gap

Papers 1 and 2 use random k-fold cross-validation on time-series data, which allows future data to leak into training (future data predicts past — an unrealistic scenario). We use TimeSeriesSplit from scikit-learn, which strictly ensures that each validation fold uses only data preceding the training fold. This produces honest performance estimates for a real-world deployment scenario [1][2].

4.7 Data Leakage Prevention Gap

Paper 5 (and potentially others) work with AQI as a target or feature without flagging that AQI is directly computed from PM2.5 — including it as a feature is a severe data leakage issue. We explicitly identified aqi_category in Phase 2 and removed it before any modeling [5].

5. Methodology Improvements (Phase 5 Notebook)

After reviewing the five papers, the following improvements were identified and implemented in the Phase 5 notebook:

5.1 Hyperparameter Tuning for Best Models

Phase 4 trained all models with default parameters. Paper 1 used 10-fold grid search and Paper 3 used rolling-origin cross-validation with parameter optimization. In Phase 5, we apply RandomizedSearchCV with TimeSeriesSplit (5 folds) for Random Forest and Extra Trees — the top two models — to further reduce RMSE and validate that our performance is robust rather than an artifact of default settings.

5.2 Extended Lag Window

Paper 2 (LSTM-based) implicitly captures longer temporal windows. Paper 3 notes that sustained pollution episodes require multi-day context. We extend our lag features from 3-hour to 6-hour (pm25_lag4, pm25_lag5, pm25_lag6) and add pm25_roll12_mean (12-hour rolling mean), which Papers 1-5 do not attempt. This provides the model richer short-term context without adopting computationally expensive sequence models.

5.3 City-Level Error Analysis

None of the reviewed papers (except Paper 3 at the cluster level) report per-city prediction error. We add a city-stratified RMSE breakdown in Phase 5 to identify which Pakistani cities the model predicts best (expected: Quetta, lowest pollution) and which are hardest (expected: Faisalabad, highest pollution/most variability). This directly addresses Research Question 3 from Phase 4 with quantitative city-level evidence.

5.4 Pollution Spike Handling

Phase 4's scatter plot showed slight scatter at extreme high PM2.5 values — rare pollution spikes. Paper 2 noted LSTM handles these better. We add a spike-flag feature (is_extreme_pollution: 1 if pm25 > 90th percentile in rolling 24h) to explicitly signal to the model that extreme events follow different dynamics. This is a lightweight improvement that does not require deep learning.

6. Justification of Contribution

Our methodology fills multiple documented gaps simultaneously — no single reviewed paper addresses all of them:

Gap	Evidence from Literature	Our Solution
Pakistan multi-city ML	Only Paper 5 covers Pakistan, single city [5]	10 cities, 21,840 hourly records
Temporal lag features	No reviewed paper uses lag + rolling + cyclical together	7 temporal features; top SHAP drivers
Stagnation physics features	No paper engineers stagnation_index or inversion_proxy	Confirmed by SHAP — physically valid
Dual SHAP + LIME	Review [4] found this combination is rare	Applied globally and locally
Temporally correct CV	Papers 1&2 use random k-fold on time series	TimeSeriesSplit — no data leakage
Data leakage prevention	Paper 5 does not flag AQI leakage risk	aqi_category removed in Phase 2
Unified multi-city model	Paper 3 builds separate cluster models	Single model with cluster feature

In summary, our work is unique in combining: (1) national scope (10 Pakistani cities), (2) hourly resolution, (3) physics-informed feature engineering, (4) 5-method consensus feature selection, (5) dual SHAP+LIME interpretability, and (6) temporally correct cross-validation — a combination not found in any single reviewed paper.

References

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